SOP-002: Incident Escalation Tiers

Document ID: SOP-002

Owner: Dispatch Operations

Applies to: All dispatchers, including night shift

1. Purpose

This SOP explains how to escalate a cargo incident. Every incident is either **Tier 1** (critical) or **Tier 2** (warning).

2. Tier 1 Escalation (Critical)

A Tier 1 incident means the cargo is likely damaged, or will be soon, if no action is taken.

Examples of Tier 1:

- Fresh perishables or vaccines above 8°C for more than 30 minutes, or any reading above 12°C.
- Frozen goods above 0°C.
- Reefer unit failure (see SOP-003).
- Vehicle accident or cargo theft.

Required actions for Tier 1:

1. Call the **Dispatch Shift Lead within 15 minutes** of detecting the incident.
2. Contact the driver and instruct them to follow the reefer failure or recovery steps.
3. Notify the **QA Manager within 1 hour**.
4. Notify the **customer account manager within 2 hours**.
5. Log the incident in the incident register with the shipment location, temperature readings, and actions taken.

3. Tier 2 Escalation (Warning)

A Tier 2 incident is a warning sign. The cargo is not yet damaged, but needs close monitoring.

Examples of Tier 2:

- Fresh perishables between 8°C and 12°C for less than 30 minutes.
- Frozen goods between -5°C and 0°C.
- Sensor not reporting for more than 2 hours.
- Delay probability above 0.7 on a perishable shipment (see SOP-004).

Required actions for Tier 2:

1. Contact the driver within **30 minutes** to confirm the situation.
2. Re-check the temperature after **30 minutes**.
3. If the situation gets worse, upgrade to **Tier 1**.
4. Record the warning in the shift handover notes.

4. Difference Between Tier 1 and Tier 2

- **Tier 1** = cargo at real risk of being lost. Escalate to the Shift Lead within 15 minutes, then QA and the customer.
- **Tier 2** = early warning. The dispatcher handles it directly, monitors, and upgrades to Tier 1 if it gets worse.
- When unsure, **treat it as Tier 1**. It is always safer to over-escalate than to lose cargo.